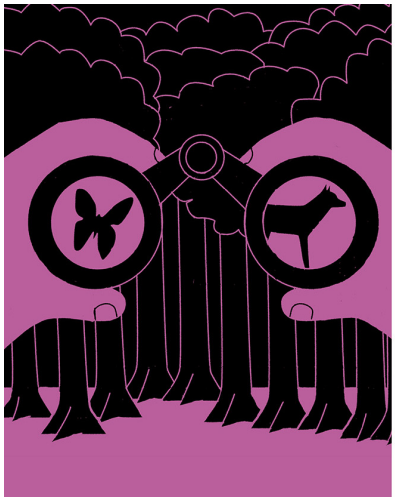


TO VISUALIZE THE BIG PICTURE, TAKE A DISTANT VIEW

MACROECOLOGY

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

James H. Brown (1942–)

BEFORE

1920 Swedish ecologist Olof Arrhenius produces a mathematical formula for the relationship between area and species diversity.

1964 British entomologist C.B. Williams documents patterns of species abundance, distribution, and diversity in his book *Patterns in the Balance of Nature*.

AFTER

2002 British ecologists Tim Blackburn and Kevin Gaston argue—contrary to some—that macroecology should be treated as a discipline distinct from biogeography.

2018 A team of scientists uses practical macroecological methods to show that bird species living on islands have relatively larger brains than their mainland relatives.

Scientists seeking faster ways to analyze and counter the many threats to plant and animal populations increasingly turn to macroecology. The term, coined by American ecologists James Brown and Brian Maurer in 1989,